Rose colored. Why was she spreading untrue rumors? Could she be jealous, or had she learned something about Rose that made her suspicious? She would speak with Reinhardt about his secretary upon his return.

It wasn't until Christmas Eve that she saw him.

"You've been away so long," she said, handing him the report.

"Did you miss me?" His tone was sharp.

"I missed our talks."

"As did I." He motioned to the chair across from the desk and then rang the bell.

Rose stiffened at the familiar creak from the side door opening. She expected a glare from Frau Birks' small, dark eyes, but the woman kept her head down, carrying the tray and setting it on the desk.

"That will be all. Goodnight, Frau Birks."

She left without a glance in Rose's direction.

"Did you travel far?" Rose asked.

"Dippoldiswalde, the district headquarters for Glashütte. Important meetings and other matters to attend to." He motioned to the tea.

Rose reached for the cup and blew on the liquid to cool it. Sensing he was a little on edge, she wondered if something had happened while he was away, something that weighed on him. She wanted to speak of André but she needed to find a way to bring him up. "Still, you must be tired with so many reports to catch up on."

"Frau Birks brought the reports by car every morning," he said in a businesslike tone. "It's a twenty-minute drive. So to answer your question, I am all caught up on the reports."

Should she mention her exchange with his secretary? Rose hesitated, unable to gauge the direction their conversation was heading.

"Frau Birks' brother resides in Dippoldiswalde." His forefinger circled the cup's rim. "He directs the Gestapo office there, which supervises the regional offices, including Glashütte. I report to him."

Her hand, still holding the cup, froze in midair. "I see."

"Do you?" His eyes, sharp as blades, locked on her. "I'm aware of what Frau Birks is saying." He cleared his throat. "Am I right that she mentioned it to you while I was away?"

Rose put the cup on the desk, forcing herself to look at him. "Yes."

"I cannot dismiss her." His mouth twitched. "I've warned her brother."